

Chapter 5

Nationalism and terror

Men must be aroused, pushed, shocked by the very benefits of their own deliverance, their eyes wounded with the truth, light thrown in terrible handfuls.

P. J. P. Tynan, *The Irish National Invincibles* (1894)

The level of shock administered to Western establishments by small-group terrorism was registered in the level of attention lavished on it. The torrent of analysis had by the 1980s created a severely distorted perspective. The persistence of the model of the individual terrorist as an alienated Western youth was remarkable: its reductive effect obscured the deeper and more varied impulses to terrorist action which, as the cultural historian Khachig Tololyan insisted, can only be grasped by cultural interpretation. We need to understand ‘the way in which different societies maintain their vision of their collective selves, and so produce different terrorisms and different terrorists’. In other words, the framework for much modern terrorist action is ethnic or nationalist; and each nationalism is culturally unique. Indeed, the emblematic terrorist act of the early 20th century—the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the throne of Austria-Hungary, at Sarajevo in June 1914—was carried out by a Serbian nationalist. The vast bulk of subsequent terrorism (whether on governmental criteria or by the more selective standards applied here) was similarly the work of nationalists.

Nationalist movements have shown much greater resilience—and destructive capacity—than the small and fissiparous left-wing revolutionary groups. They tend to be significantly bigger, for one thing, and to draw on a broader pool of

recruitment; and though their ‘cause’—freeing or uniting the nation—is not necessarily more practicable than the revolutionary dream of total social transformation, nationalism has dominated modern politics precisely because it connects with a visceral, apparently natural force. (In fact, the principle of national self-determination, the idea that nations should possess political sovereignty in order to realize their cultural distinctness, is an intellectual invention of the 19th century.) Thus even a nation whose struggle seems objectively doomed to failure (say the Chechens, or indeed the Irish as defined by the republican movement) may never give up; while an ethnic group such as the Tamil Tigers (Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam, LTTE) reached stratospheric levels of deadliness—well over 100,000 were killed by them in their thirty-three-year career.

Tololyan’s own example, the Armenians, provide a potent illustration—‘a deadly and important manifestation of international terrorism’. Modern Armenian terrorism dates from 1890 (a vital epoch in the national revival throughout Europe), when the ‘Dashnags’ (Hye Heghaphkhaganneri Dashnagtzootyun; Federation of Armenian Revolutionaries) were organized in imitation of the Narodniki. But their actions, like those of subsequent Armenian groups—most famously the attempted seizure of the Turkish Embassy in Lisbon by the Armenian Revolutionary Army (ARA) in 1983—were shaped by a long historical memory reaching back to the legendary struggle of Vartan against the Persians c. AD 450. This was a religious rather than a ‘national’ defence, but it has become incorporated with later struggles, above all the massacres of the 1890s and ‘the genocide’ of 1916, into what Tololyan calls a ‘typological-prefigurative narrative’—a story of the people in which historical changes of context are elided: past and future become one whole. Where the nation is without a state, the task of preserving cultural identity is at its most demanding, and the requirement of action most pressing. ‘We know what must be done.’

In the nationalist worldview, the rights of all nations are equal, whatever their size, location, or practical viability. The prime issue is one of consciousness: whether the members of the nation itself are convinced of their collective identity as envisaged by the nationalists. (Witness the Armenian nationalist anxiety about assimilation, which they call ‘white massacre’, or Irish nationalist reaction against ‘Anglicization’.) Lack of national consciousness is seen as evidence of the cultural peril they must fight. Terrorism may play a leading part in the attempt to preserve or ‘reawaken’ the national spirit, and also in the

accompanying (or maybe resulting) struggle against a foreign or imperial government. But there is another and possibly more intractable problem: what all too often stands in the way of national liberation movements is not only the foreign government, but the fact that people of other ethnic groups live within the presumed national territory. (It seems to be the junction of socially constructed unity—culture—with occupation of land that persuades people that the nation is a natural, or even divinely ordained, unit; but it is seldom a neat one.) These other groups may resist incorporation within the insurgent nation. In this case, another dimension of terrorism may appear; the communal slaughter which has now come to be called by the (nationalist) euphemism ‘ethnic cleansing’. Even if they do not resist, the result may be the same. Nationalists are intolerant of diversity or plurality; as an unkind critic puts it, ‘nationalism is driven by a bovine will to simplify things’.

Once rooted, nationalist ‘causes’ are hardly ever given up—in modern times, despite predictions that the world is moving into a post-national age, they look virtually indestructible. A number of nationalist groups have maintained terrorist campaigns for a generation or more, and to grasp the reasons for this we need, even more than in the case of revolutionary terror, to know their history.

The case of Irish republicanism

The longest-lived of them, so far, is the Irish republican movement, whose most recent armed campaign lasted thirty years, and which can confidently trace its ancestry back another century. And though tactics have varied over time, the IRA (see [Chapter 1](#)), whether Official, Provisional, Continuity, or Real, still follows the operating logic laid down by the Irish Revolutionary Brotherhood in the 1850s. In terms of organization and method, the continuity may be thought to stretch yet further back, into the agrarian terrorism of the Catholic ‘Defenders’ of the 18th century. (Though whether these represented the Irish nation is still a sensitive political question.) It is worth pondering the reasons for this almost unblinking commitment to the use of political violence.

The original ‘physical force’ movement, the Irish Republican Brotherhood (IRB; colloquially known as the Fenians; ‘the Organization’ to its members) began life around 1858 as a classical insurrectionist group, believing that a small armed vanguard could energize and lead the people in open rebellion. It faced two

primary difficulties: first, organizing in secret to avoid police surveillance; and, second, choosing the critical moment to raise the flag of revolt. The imperative of security impelled them to follow the organizational pattern of continental freemasonry, with a sequence of carefully controlled levels of initiation. This, ironically, made them resemble the oath-bound agrarian secret societies like 'Captain Moonlight' which fought for control of the land in Ireland, a struggle which the Fenians themselves rejected as debasing the cause of national independence. Oath-bound secrecy also led them to fall foul of the Catholic Church, which condemned them as free-thinking subversives. Their biggest problem, though, was that a secret organization could do little to prepare the people for the insurrectionary moment. It had to trust that the innate (as it hoped) popular desire for national independence would be ignited by the spark of armed action, and impel the masses to rise up against the government. This did not happen—in Ireland, in Italy, or anywhere else that insurrectionist groups patiently organized and waited.

The republican shift to terrorism, which might be thought inevitable from a 20th-century perspective, was surprisingly hesitant and contested. The failure of 'military' Fenianism—the apparently promising idea of infiltrating the Irish regiments of the British Army to turn their rank and file against Britain—in 1864–6 was followed by a 'spectacular' action, the 1867 Clerkenwell explosion, which may be seen as the world's first urban bombing. But it was accidental, and was not repeated. The leaders of the Fenian organization in Ireland, committed to the concept of 'honourable warfare', associated terrorism with the murky activities of the agrarian secret societies. Yet the Clerkenwell explosion had a far bigger impact on British politics than any of the IRB's 'honourable' military efforts. It led to two major reforms, launched by Gladstone in 1868 under the banner of 'pacifying Ireland'. The IRB Supreme Council was unmoved by these achievements, though, judging them irrelevant, or even damaging, to the struggle for national liberation.

Other Irish republicans were less fastidious. Both O'Donovan Rossa's Skirmishers and the Irish-American Clan na Gael adopted frankly terrorist methods in the 1880s, the latter clearly influenced by anarchist and populist action. Rossa (who stuck to gunpowder) seemed to accept that even if he could do no more than 'hurt England' that would be enough. But the Clan went for the full dynamite effect. Yet its explosions in London, though bigger than in 1867, achieved less—mainly, in an early illustration of a classic pattern, they initiated

the erosion of traditional English freedoms, notably via the creation of Britain's first political police, the Irish Special Branch. Later revolutionary terrorist strategists would see this process as part of a radicalization of the struggle, but for the Irish republicans, the British failed to overreact sufficiently. This unpredictability of reaction represents a central weakness in the terror process. (Box 5.)

Box 5

Such a strategy relies on the premise that the British people do not support British government sponsored murder in Ireland, that they want their troops withdrawn from Ireland, as indicated in opinion polls, and that they have the potential to eventually force the British government because of the cost of the war or the attrition rate or because of the demoralisation and war weariness, to withdraw from Ireland.

Provisional IRA statement, *An Phoblacht/Republican News*, 5 January 1984

By contrast with the Clan's embrace of the new technology of high explosives, the most resonant of all the Irish 'terrorist' actions of this time, the 1882 Phoenix Park assassinations of the two leading members of the Irish government, was carried out with surgical knives. (Helping to ensure, among other things, that in future ministers would seldom be allowed to walk about unguarded.) By contrast, too, the political message of this act was hard to decipher, since the 'Irish National Invincibles' never carried out another, or issued any political manifesto. If the killing of Gladstone's son-in-law pushed him towards Home Rule, was this what the Invincibles wanted?

The failure of the Clan dynamite campaign brought direct Irish-American violent action in Britain to a surprisingly complete end, in contrast with the extraordinary resilience of the 'physical force' movement in Ireland itself. (They deployed the potent symbol of the 'phoenix flame' which would rekindle from its own ashes.) Its apparent decay around the turn of the century coincided with a major re-invigoration, and refocusing, of Irish cultural identity through the 'Gaelic revival'. The dramatic insurrection in Dublin in 1916 represented a

fusion of the old organization with the explicitly ethnic objectives formulated by Patrick Pearse—‘Ireland not free merely, but Gaelic also’. In Pearse’s writing, the ‘resonating roll-call that blurs history, context and nuance’, which Tololyan identifies as the core of national ideology, is startlingly vivid. His call to violent action, too, was suffused with the ideal of ‘death knowingly grasped’ so central to the Armenian Vartan story—as, indeed, was the martyrdom of hunger-striking republican prisoners after the failure of the rising, most famously Thomas Ashe in 1917 and Terence MacSwiney in 1920.

Though Irish republicanism’s commitment to physical force was consistent, its ambivalence about terrorist methods was partly due to the imprecision of its thinking about the utility of violence as such. Was the point of violent action simply to ‘hurt England’—in the hope presumably that Britain would eventually get fed up and quit—or could it directly drive out the enemy? Given the huge disparity in available force, the second idea was almost literally suicidal. But it seems to have been what motivated most ‘physical force men’. Research into the IRA’s mainland campaign, for instance, has shown little in the way of reasoning about the effect of ‘operations abroad’, beyond the need to find ‘something to do’ and the urge to ‘do to you what you are doing to Ireland’, as one of the Manchester arsonists of April 1921 put it. Wild terrorist projects were framed by Cathal Brugha, though Michael Collins, using a more realistic test of their utility, repeatedly interfered to shut them down.

By contrast, terrorism against ‘spies and informers’ played a central role in the republican guerrilla campaign in the Irish countryside, where the old grammar of agrarian intimidation was absorbed into the new logic of nationalism. Most crucially, IRA violence provoked a British counterterror that severely damaged the remaining legitimacy of the government. The ‘Black and Tans’, a semi-military temporary force recruited in Britain, became a byword for how-not-to combat a modern insurgency. Even though they were quite successful in persuading the Irish public to distance themselves from IRA activity, their methods raised a storm of public criticism. By 1921, the IRA could claim to have withstood the worst that the British Empire could throw at it; its survival became a beacon of hope to nationalist resistance movements all over the world. Yet by its own criteria republicanism had failed. After the split and the Civil War of 1922–3, the IRA opted out of politics, and launched two unequivocally terrorist campaigns: the ‘mainland’ bombing campaign of 1938–9 and the border campaign of 1956–62; both petered out without causing much stir. By the mid-

1960s, the ‘physical force’ idea was probably more marginalized than at any time in its history; the dramatic revival of terrorist action in the 1970s would have been impossible to predict. It followed the chaotic breakdown of the dominant Unionist group in Northern Ireland in face of demands for reform. The Provisional IRA emerged as a communal defence force in 1970 and can plausibly be seen as a national liberation front with a sideline in terrorist action, rather than as a terrorist organization. A handful of ‘spectaculars’ were accompanied by many more street-level killings representing an ongoing vendetta between republican and loyalist paramilitaries rather than a serious attempt to influence public opinion.

It remained unusually resilient, for various reasons. Crucially, the number of volunteers required for active service at any time was in the low hundreds, and recruitment was never difficult because of the organization’s deep roots in the nationalist community. Its self-image as a people’s army (in the nationalist not Maoist sense, though the blurring has sometimes been encouraged) survived replacement of traditional military structure by cellular organization from the late 1970s onwards. (As the IRA Army Council’s ‘Green Book’ declared, ‘Commitment to the Army is total belief in the Army ... that the Army is the direct representative of the 1918 Dail.’) Its self-belief, fuelled by potent historical legend and reinforced by contemporary successes, generated a robust faith in the cause—both its abstract justice and its pragmatic feasibility (despite long-term evidence to the contrary)—resting on a belief that the essential unity and fraternity of the Irish people (including many who apparently repudiate this allegiance) is only fractured by deliberate British interference. As one investigator found, ‘relatively few individuals offer sophisticated political justifications of violence, yet all show a strength of what can only be described as a belief in the rightness of their actions’.

Bringing such an organization back into the realm of politics is a complicated business. Though the British government proclaimed this as its objective (urging republicans to renounce violence), its policies had the opposite effect. It made a determined effort to pin the ‘terrorist’ label on the Provisional IRA through the policy of ‘criminalization’ in the late 1970s, starting with the withdrawal of the political status given to republican internees. (Admittedly, the idea of ‘political status’ had always been dubious in British law—a point Mrs Thatcher relentlessly proclaimed with her mantra ‘crime is crime is crime’—but the decision to make an issue of this was significant.) The IRA’s response, the

hunger strike campaign, equally proclaimed its determination to assert its belligerent status. Though some analysts have been prepared to classify hunger strikes as terrorist actions, public perceptions of self-sacrifice have been different—awe, tinged with admiration, perhaps, rather than fear. The outcome of the struggle was a moral defeat for the government which paved the way for the cautious re-entry of the physical force leadership into politics, whose outcome still hangs in the balance.

Violence or politics: the case of ETA

An ambivalent relationship with politics has also characterized the most persistent of the other ethnic terrorist organizations in Europe, the Basque separatist ETA (see [Chapter 2](#)). Created in 1959, but drawing like the IRA on a long-established cultural resistance movement (and also a strong Catholic ethos), ETA defined itself as a movement of national liberation and not a political party. It engaged rather more openly with the question of Basque national identity itself than did the IRA with that of ‘Irishness’ (an issue the IRA was reluctant to highlight). The Basque country had, like Ireland but for different reasons, been flooded with migrants (from Spain), drawn by its rapid economic development in the 19th century. ETA departed from earlier racial theories and also rejected any religious dimension by advocating strict secularism: the objective was to assimilate anyone who was prepared to use the Basque language. (This line was initiated in Ireland also by the Gaelic language movement at the end of the 19th century, but by that time the Irish people themselves had abandoned the language and have not subsequently been persuaded to re-adopt it.)

ETA is rhetorically at least a socialist revolutionary as well as a nationalist movement, but though it often levied ‘revolutionary taxation’ at gunpoint, its attacks have mostly been directed at representatives of the Spanish state rather than the often-denounced industrial capitalists. Though it is no more prepared than any contemporary organization to accept the label terrorist, the carefully controlled tempo of its campaign and the symbolic nature of its selected targets have distanced it from even the Provisional IRA’s approximation of a guerrilla insurgency. In the period from the start of the military campaign in June 1968 to the end of 1980 (analysed by Robert Clark, 1984), it killed 287 people and injured about 400. Significantly, very few of these casualties were inflicted under the Franco regime: the ETA campaign accelerated after the election of the first democratic assembly in 1977, and peaked with the granting of autonomy and the

election of the Basque assembly in 1980—it killed nearly a hundred people in that year. Its use of indiscriminate attacks remained sparing (though, as in the bombing of Madrid airport and railway stations in July 1979, still very shocking). Overall, its targeting was focused primarily on the Guardia Civil and the police. It showed a marked preference for the use of comparatively accurate weapons—small arms rather than explosives—and a determination repeatedly to attack high-ranking officials and officers, the highest being Admiral Carrero Blanco in 1973, and others, including the military governors of Madrid and Guipúzcoa in 1979. But it also achieved a big shock effect by kidnapping an obscure local councillor of the governing Partido Popular in July 1997, and killing him when the government refused its demand to relocate ETA prisoners to the Basque country.

What has it achieved? The killing of Carrero Blanco, one of the most spectacular of all assassinations, in which the prime minister's car was blown 70 feet in the air by a mine, may have brought the Francoist system to an end. But ETA was no more kindly disposed to the Spanish democracy that followed it. Its campaign has the hallmarks of 'classical' terrorism, operating at a tangent to politics on the assumption that it can connect with deeper realities. ETA has rejected concessions that have gone far beyond the reforms that the Narodniki said they would accept, and that the Provisional IRA accepted. (Or at least the military section, ETAm, has done so; the 'political-military', ETAp, has largely accepted constitutionalism and many of its members took up the official amnesty, being allowed to 're-enter' society on condition they forswore violence.) As in Ireland, there is a deep rift between nationalists who can accommodate to a kind of autonomy and those who hold to the purist separatist ideal. As one of ETA's young women leaders put it, 'if we don't fight, the Basques will perish as a people'. The attractive power of the ideal may still burn brightly, above all for Basque youth.

ETA sometimes acknowledged mistakes, as when it apologized after bombing a Madrid supermarket in 1987. But its ferocity was as daunting as its internal discipline. Like the IRA it declared a number of truces and ceasefires during its fifty-year campaign of violence. These were not taken seriously enough to allow any progress to political negotiations, and the movement was widely seen as irredeemably militarist. The Spanish state's deep hostility to armed separatism was demonstrated in the government's attempt, without any evidence at all, to pin the 2004 Madrid train bombings on ETA. In March 2006, and again in

September 2010, ETA declared ceasefires, the last of these being declared 'permanent' in January 2011. (Sinn Féin under Gerry Adams claimed to have helped persuade the movement to return to politics.)

ETA was unusual among nationalists in studiously avoiding targeting other ethnic groups—something the IRA certainly failed to do (while protesting that it did: Protestants were allegedly attacked not *qua* Protestants, or foreigners, but as security force members or helpers—implausible in the bombings at Enniskillen (see [Figure 6](#)) or Omagh). The IRA have been more typical in this. The logic of national liberation, however liberal its rhetoric, requires a coherent national community which is necessarily defined by its contrast with outsiders. Protecting this exclusivity is indeed the essence of nationalism. (Even though there have been socialist revolutionaries, like Connolly, who thought that national liberation was the first step towards international brotherhood, they have all been disappointed.) So the possibility that violence will be turned not only against the oppressor state but also against other ethnic groups is implicit.



6. The bomb placed in Enniskillen by the IRA on 8 November 1987 was

deliberately aimed at a key symbol of Unionist identity, a Remembrance Day parade: eleven were killed and sixty-three injured.

Ethnic terror has shown little sign of dying out in the 20th century—if anything the reverse. In Belfast, for instance, the communal violence unleashed in July 1920 lasted on and off for two years, and killed more people than had died in all the many riots of the 19th century put together. Thousands of Catholic —‘Nationalist’—families were driven from their homes by arson and assault, as the Protestant majority tidied up the borders of its neighbourhoods. The same thing was repeated on a still more extended timescale after 1968; and even as the ‘peace process’ appeared to be taking firm root around the millennium, a ferocious territorial struggle broke out over the access of Catholic children to a primary school in Ardoyne. Was this terrorism or, as some might say, just general terror? The violence is indirect and intimidatory as much as coercive, certainly, although its intent is not to convert but to drive out those who identify with the victims. But there is little sign of deliberate planning or organization. Perhaps here language reaches its useful limits; where fear and suspicion are so deeply entrenched, there is no need or even possibility of strategic thinking: action is reflexive and visceral. (Obedient, almost, to Bismarck’s deadly injunction, ‘Germans! Think with your blood!’)

Zionism and the problem of territory

The potential of nationalism to generate double-edged terrorism is starkly demonstrated in the history of Zionism in Palestine. The Zionist idea, the ‘return’ of the Jewish diaspora to Eretz Israel, incorporated both the central objectives of modern nationalism: the spiritual self-realization of the ‘cultural’ nation, and its physical security against external threats. (Security in particular was, for Jews in Eastern Europe, always under threat.) When Britain committed itself through the 1917 Balfour Declaration to ‘the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people’, it did not grasp either the full implications of these objectives, or the difficulty of fulfilling them against Arab resistance. Jewish security could be achieved in either of two ways: by befriending the Arab population or by neutralizing, if not removing it. A minority of Zionists (notably the tiny Brit Shalom group) pursued the first course; another minority (the ‘Revisionists’ led by Vladimir Jabotinsky) insisted that Jews must be prepared to fight for statehood. The majority simply hoped for the best.

The international Zionist Organization and the majority of the Yishuv (the Jewish community living in Palestine at that time) were committed to reliance on Britain, but even they immediately set about establishing a semi-open defensive force (Haganah) in response to the first Arab attacks on Jewish settlements in 1920. The repetition of those attacks in 1921 and, more violently, in 1929 were a terrible trauma for moderate Zionists: the movement really faced either abandoning the entire project of building a 'national home' in Palestine or accepting that it could only be done by force. The majority was eventually brought to accept this by Britain's ungenerous policy during the Holocaust, but the Revisionists were already prepared for a showdown long before the Jewish community had even become one-third of Palestine's population. There would certainly have been a significant Jewish terrorist campaign during the Arab rebellion of 1936–9 but for the fact that Arab violence was primarily directed at the British authorities; the terrorism that appeared was mainly action by the Arab guerrilla fighters, or *mujahideen*, against their rivals for leadership of the Palestinian Arab people—internal enforcement terror.

Jewish terrorist action took off towards the end of the Second World War with the assassination in Cairo in 1944 of Lord Moyne by the 'Stern Gang', an outgrowth of the Revisionist movement. But though the campaigns of the Irgun Zvai Leumi (IZL) and Lehi (Lohamei Heruth Israel; Freedom Fighters for Israel, or FFI) are routinely labelled terrorist—and indeed they are presented as textbook examples of the efficacy of terrorism in certain circumstances—we need to register that, apart from a small number of spectacular operations—the bombing of the King David Hotel in Jerusalem in July 1946 being the most deadly terrorist attack so far—their targeting was precise and mainly military. (The King David itself housed British military headquarters, though most of the casualties were local civilians; see [Figure 7](#).) The British Army disliked calling its Jewish opponents terrorists—though the government insisted on this—because of the implication that its troops were frightened by them. Before its first and most famous operation, the assassination of Lord Moyne in 1944, Lehi accepted the term as it had been used by the Russian Populists, and maintained that 'terror is, for us, part of contemporary political warfare'. But it was realistic about its limits: in 1943 its publicity sheet *HeChazit* declared, 'If the question is, is it possible to bring about liberation by means of terror? the answer is: No! If the question is, do these actions help to bring liberation nearer? the answer is: Yes!' It also explained its function: 'It is not aimed at persons, but at representatives and is therefore effective. And if it also shakes the population out

of its complacency, so much the better.'



7. The destruction of the south wing of the King David Hotel in Jerusalem by the Irgun on 22 July 1946 killed ninety-one people, mostly civilian employees of the British government and military authorities in Palestine.

In fact, it proved to deliver much more than this cautious estimate. The fact that Moyne himself, a former colonial secretary who had presided over Britain's policy of excluding Jewish refugees from Palestine (and so was certainly seen as a legitimate target), was a friend of Winston Churchill, probably the only remaining pro-Zionist British senior politician, magnified the effect of his killing. While Churchill abandoned plans to partition Palestine and create a Jewish state, issuing doom-laden warnings about the termination of the Zionist dream 'in the smoke of assassins' pistols', Revisionists had long since written off

British goodwill as useless. Their violent campaign played a central part in bringing the majority of the Yishuv around to their view. Here the classic terrorist argument that government repression would drive the people on to the side of the terrorists was borne out. (As, too, in Ireland in 1920–1.) The British proved unexpectedly incompetent and irresolute repressors, quickly demoralized by the energy and ruthlessness of the Jewish campaign. When they abandoned Palestine in 1948 they did so in a way that created the maximum chaos—a situation the terrorists were ideally positioned to exploit.

The difficulty of writing objectively about terrorism is starkly illustrated by the fact that even those studies that provide a clear and critical account of the Jewish terrorist campaign stop dead at the point of the British decision to withdraw from Palestine. (Loaded works such as those by Netanyahu, so prominent in the published literature, don't mention Jewish terrorism at all; for them terrorism in Palestine is exclusively Arab.) Yet the subsequent campaign of the PLO (see [Chapter 2](#)) is quite literally incomprehensible without an understanding of the grim aftermath in which the Jewish state substantially enlarged its share (allotted by a United Nations Special Commission) of Palestine's land area causing the Palestine Arab state to collapse. Most writers put this struggle in the category of war—international rather than civil. This reflects the Israeli state's foundation myth, that it was attacked by an overwhelming combination of Arab states. In this life-and-death struggle, the Arab inhabitants of Palestine became legitimate targets. And while there was indeed a military reason for occupying such villages as Deir Yassin, there was none for the massacre of their inhabitants (who were known to be non-resistant), save the belief that every Arab was a threat. If this was indeed war, these were war crimes—but they were more than that; they were a system. The Deir Yassin attack was carried out by members of the Irgun and Lehi, disavowed by the official Zionist leaders; but after the incorporation of the former terrorists ('dissidents' in official language) with the Haganah and Palmach into a new Israeli army, the violent clearance of Arab communities continued. (One expellee was the Christian George Habash of Lydda, later to lead the PFLP.) The transmission of terror produced a growing tide of refugees, the permanent victims of *al-Nakbah*, the 'disaster'.

Can terror liberate nations?

Jewish terrorism proved stronger than both its key opponents. But this outcome was rare indeed. By contrast, the campaigns of the PLO, and the more radical

PFLP (see [Chapter 4](#)), have been much longer than those of the Irgun and Lehi, but far less successful. Indeed, they could in one sense be argued to have been counterproductive: the general position of the Arabs of Palestine is dramatically worse than it was at the outset of the ‘international’ terrorist campaign in 1969. Symbolic gains such as the Hamas and PLO-controlled administrations in Gaza and Jericho must be weighed against steady erosion of territory and a more rigid frontier. Beyond doubt, though, the use of high-profile terrorism in the 1970s brought the Palestinian case to world attention in a way that two decades of suffering in comparative silence had not.

In fact, terrorist action had been initiated by Palestinian refugees since the early 1950s, but the main result had been the provocation of major Israeli military action—ultimately the two crushing wars of 1956 and 1967. And, as George Habash of the PFLP said, the world ignored them. The effect of the PFLP’s hijacking of an El Al airliner on 22 July 1968 was radically different. ‘When we hijack a plane it has more effect than if we killed a hundred Israelis in battle’—as Habash exulted in 1970: ‘the world is talking about us now’. The talk became deafening after what may be regarded as the emblematic terrorist action of the later 20th century: the seizure of Israeli athletes at the Munich Olympics in 1972. The international reaction was far-reaching: on the one hand the recognition of the PLO as a kind of virtual government-in-exile; and on the other the proliferation of expensive, burdensome, and possibly dangerous security measures (see [Chapter 7](#)). But its impact on the policy of Israel, which has responded (consistently with Revisionist thinking) with disproportionate and fairly approximate ‘retaliation’, and increasing colonization of the territories occupied in 1967, is less clear. (See [Figure 8](#).)



8. One of the most characteristic actions in the Palestinian conflict: twenty-two ordinary Israelis were killed when this bus was bombed by Hamas in Jerusalem in February 1996.

So the undoubted success of Zionist terrorism in creating a Jewish state was qualified in the longer term by a legacy of violence, generated (as in Ireland) by partition. Partition was also the outcome of the almost-successful campaign of *Ethniki Organosis Kyprion Agoniston* (EOKA) in Cyprus in the 1950s. The organization's title, besides demonstrating the merging of ethnic and national, indicated its lack of appeal to the Turkish population of the island. Despite the clinical efficiency of its guerrilla terrorist campaign in undermining British power, it failed to achieve its declared political aim of *enosis* (union with Greece) or its fundamental—if unspoken—aim of liberating the whole island.

The effectiveness of terrorism in achieving national liberation also appeared to be demonstrated in the Algerian war of independence. The FLN (see [Chapter 3](#)) launched its rebellion in 1954 but was making little progress until it adopted in 1956 the terrorist logic advocated by Ramdane Abane, who urged that a single

killing in Algiers—where the US press would report it—was more effective than ten in the remote countryside. Abane insisted that the morality of terrorism simply paralleled that of government repression: ‘I see little difference between the girl who places a bomb in the Milk-Bar and the aviator who bombs a village or drops napalm in a *zone interdite*.’

The most careful assessment of FLN terror in Algeria has concluded that terrorism ‘was integral to the revolution’. ‘It served major political objectives’—securing the FLN’s popular credibility and its internal cohesion, damaging the colonial regime, and enhancing the FLN’s ‘image of strength and determination abroad’. But for all its high profile, FLN terrorism was part of a wider campaign, including rural guerrilla warfare, non-violent methods, and the establishment of a counter-government ‘that was more effective than the French administration’. (A significant parallel with the Irish republican campaign of 1919–21.) Terrorism was particularly effective in launching the insurgency, but it went on being used when it was not necessary or functional. This does seem to indicate the danger that a kind of organizational habit of terror, with its low costs and scattergun effects, may become ingrained. And where that happens, the price of freedom may be higher than it first appears: it may have, as the jurist Richard Falk suggests, ‘corrupting consequences that reverberate for decades’. At the end of the 20th century, the Algerian government was facing the eighth year of a ‘terrorist’ campaign mounted by the Armed Islamic Group (GIA) and the Salafi Group for Call and Combat (GSPC). According to official figures, this had killed no fewer than 100,000 people.

What this means in human terms may be hinted at by this extract from the diary of a Kabyle schoolteacher in the midst of the FLN campaign of the 1950s:

Toward noon I made a rapid tour of the town. People seem tense, ready for any madness, any anger, any stupidity. I felt through the crowd an impression of horror, as though I were living in the midst of a nightmare. An indefinable curse reigns over us. ... At each execution of a traitor, or pretended such, anguish seizes the survivors. Nobody is sure of anything, it is truly terror. Terror of the soldier, terror of the outlaw. Each of us is guilty just because he belongs to such a category, such a race, such a people. You fear they will make you pay with your life for your place in the world or the colour of your skin. ... you wonder why you don’t do anything—even sincerely mourn the victims, mourn them in the shadow of that secret and inadmissible joy which is that of the escapee.